

you're required to pay it all the same in the case of a permanent separation. Pets should be addressed, especially any animals you adopt together. And don't forget vacation property, timeshares, and lake houses. I've heard the horror stories. A prized cottage in Cape Cod in one family for generations slips into the hands of the second wife or husband, even though the marriage lasted only a few years. Keep your requests simple and clear. It will save you a lot of money on lawyers later, and limit the opportunity for loopholes.

Say no to sunset clauses. This feature renders the prenup null and void after ten or fifteen years. A sunset clause gives a couple something to reach for, because they think they've made it past a certain hump and true love can then prevail. I do not recommend this. A lot of marriages explode in the twilight years. Love is treacherous at any time. That's not a bad thing; it makes you stay on your toes.

Keep legal contact to a bare minimum. Some of my friends are divorce lawyers. They make a lot of money filling out paperwork, but much of that income is earned answering teary phone calls and frantic emails from clients. Lawyers are good listeners. They're also going to bill you for every single tear, so hash it out over beers with your squash buddy, or commiserate with a friend. Call your lawyer only when you have an important legal question, and never, ever use your lawyer as a therapist. It's too expensive!

Money Mistake: You Think Marriage Means Mixing Finances

THE FIX: SLEEP TOGETHER, KEEP MONEY APART

Marriage means you can share a bed and split groceries, closet space, and chores, but it doesn't mean you have to merge your money. My mother and stepfather spent decades traveling around the world. In all that time, my mother grew her Secret 10—which wasn't a secret, really, but no one had any idea just how much was in her account until she passed away. George and my mother didn't merge money. They lived on George's income, and Georgette saved and invested hers. That was their choice, and it worked for them.